But when, at the end of each meeting, the time came to decide on the language of the "decision" items, it was his own views that were reflected. It was rare for him to have to present his proposals for a vote in the government. In most cases, he gave the ministers the opportunity to express themselves and in the end he convinced them to adopt his view. In other cases, the discussion did not even reach that point, and the ministers simply accepted his opinion, even if they had some reservations.

At a meeting on December 23, 1956, Ben-Gurion focused the discussion on what he dubbed "the Gaza problem," "especially what will happen after the first week of January (1957) when we reach El-Arish. We have more time for consultations. There are two more weeks. That's why I wanted Abba Eban, to the extent possible, to clarify the position of the American government, as it largely determines matters at the UN."

In analyzing the Gaza issue, it is worth quoting Ben-Gurion's exact words:

> I want to say that on the matter of Gaza I had no opinion for a long time, because I saw both the negative and the positive aspects of all of the proposals. Some say that the State of Israel should annex Gaza. There are those—not here—who say that Gaza should be internationalized. It is now clear that the news of a few days ago that Egypt does not intend to return to Gaza is incorrect. Fawzi announced that Egypt does intend to return to Gaza. One thing that everyone can agree on is that Egypt should not return to Gaza, and we must try to stop it from doing so. After examining the matter closely, I think that the *annexation* of Gaza, that is, making Gaza a legal part of the State of Israel— would be *a disaster for Israel*. We cannot absorb another 300,000 Arabs in the country. . . . Complete UN control of Gaza poses a danger to security. . . . The matter of demilitarization is in great doubt, though it is being discussed in many places. But England and France will not have much influence at the UN General Assembly this year, and the fact that Selwyn Lloyd [the British foreign minister] supports demilitarization does not mean anything. We do not know what the others are saying, because there is firstly the problem of sovereignty. If they demand demilitarization here, too—we have a small country and every bit of land is important.
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> The Egyptians did not intend to settle the Sinai. It cannot be settled, it is only a military base. We have no land that is only a military base. It is therefore doubtful whether there will be demilitarization. If the UN has full control of Gaza, it will become a Fedayeen base, which will be difficult to fight. Even if it is not the Yugoslav army there, let's say it will be a Danish army, even the most friendly one, it will not be able to prevent Fedayeen attacks, and we will not attack a UN army there.
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> Therefore, it seems to me that the best way out—and this is not to say that this is already a given politically, but that this is what we should strive towards, which will require taking certain actions—the best option, in my opinion, is *de facto rule by the State of Israel, de facto rather than de jure*. This means that the State of Israel will provide all services, transportation, for example—by the way, at the moment the only way to reach even El-Arish is via Haifa. The food that UNRWA sends to Gaza must be sent through Haifa, and we then transfer it by train to Gaza. We will have to provide all services to Gaza, and assistance to the refugees, which is UNRWA's business. We will open legal services, schools, transportation services, and police services there.